

ANTHROPOLOGY REVIEW

Student Research Journal



2023-24



LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

Dear Reader,

Since 2021, Anthropy has provided an outreach platform for students to foster early intellectual curiosity and meaningful engagement within the humanities and social sciences.

We empower students to explore their research interests with academic rigor, connect with experts, and share their insights with the broader community. Through our signature events, such as Humanities Focus Weeks, students gain invaluable exposure to thought leaders, including ambassadors, authors, professors, and changemakers across disciplines.

It is with great pride that we present the inaugural edition of the *Anthropy Review*, a journal celebrating the outstanding work of our student researchers.

We are equally delighted to launch *Into2Academia*, our flagship research program, this year. This pioneering initiative introduces students to the academic research process through a structured curriculum designed by published researchers and one-on-one mentorship from expert mentors. We hope this edition offers a compelling preview of the high-caliber research future participants can expect to produce as part of the program.

Sincerely,
Julia Piórko Bermig
Editor-in-Chief,
Anthropy Review



ABSTRACT

The issue's papers are from a wide range of content. Examining the contraction between the increasing need for climate change and the ever-present capitalist modes of production, Alex Wondra explores this issue in his "The Struggle Between the Need For Climate Action and the Drive to Make Profit." Jimmy Ji explores the dualities of taxation on the economy in his "Is Tax A Legal Disguise for Theft?"

Shifting the focus to a particular nation in Asia, Xiaoyao Lu reveals the problematic legacies of more traditional views on unwed women in China in his "Intersectional Pressures on Unwed Women in Urban China." Focusing on another part of the world with ongoing conflict with Russia and Ukraine, Alex To and Jack Que evaluates "The Use of Telegram in the Russian-Ukrainian War."

Finally, Jason R. writes a compelling account of narratives of different news sources through "To What Extent Do Different News Sources Engage In Media Manipulation Through Headlines?" Each brings an impressive amount of research and a singular voice to their writing.

Our academic research journal supported these authors through several revisions last year: each gave up hours of their time each week to create our journal zero. We are grateful to our editors and editorial board for their skilled assistance and valuable insights.

*Best Regards,
Ai Jian and Myra Dhingra
Co-Chairs of Marketing & Communications*



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FROM 'PASSIONS OF THE CUT SLEEVE' TO LGBT CENSORSHIP: HOW CHINA 'LEARNED' HOMOPHOBIA

WRITTEN BY MARCUS LU
EDITED BY EVEY FIRTH AND JIANSHENG ZHANG

1. HOMOSEXUALITY IN IMPERIAL AND MODERN CHINA

China is known for its conservative attitude towards homosexuality, evident in the recent efforts of social media platforms Sina Weibo and WeChat to remove homosexual content; the latter being successful. In China, there is a prevalent culture of "don't ask, don't tell" around homosexuality. The pride flag is not widely recognised, and references to LGBT individuals are often censored in the media and omitted from education. Additionally, only 18% of gay men come out to their families, and a large majority (80-90%) of Chinese gay men are married to women. Whilst China hosts the world's largest lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender (LGBT) community, this remains largely invisible to the wider society. The government itself offers little to no acknowledgement of or concessions to the allowance of "non-traditional lifestyles."

Unsurprisingly, my early education in China had conveniently left out anything remotely related to homosexuality. For this reason, the video "China's Most Bisexual Dynasty - Han Emperors and Their Male Favourites" caught my eye. I was surprised to learn that many emperors of the Han Dynasty (206 B.C. - 220 A.D.) had well-documented male favourites.

The most notable of these was Dong Xian, who, on one fine afternoon, was sleeping on the same straw mat as Emperor Ai. The emperor's sleeve had wound up underneath the resting Dong Xian. So, of course, Ai cut off his sleeve to avoid disturbing his lover. This was more than an isolated example of an Emperor's preferences, because after this romantic occurrence, "cutting the sleeve" became a fashion among the nobility in imitation of the emperor—which indicates a clear lack of discrimination against Ai and Dong's relationship despite its homosexual nature. This apparent acceptance of homosexuality was reflected not only in legendary love stories but also in literature, historical records and laws and court cases. When laws against homosexual activity first appeared during the Ming Dynasty (1368–1644), only the penetrator was punished, and not for breaking a moral standard of heterosexuality, but for degrading the masculinity of another man. In fact, it was grouped with assault and fighting rather than sexual offences. Further, during the Qing dynasty, court cases suggest that social attitudes towards same-sex relationships were not inherently hostile and that a man who took on a penetrating role in such a relationship was even seen as something to be flaunted. Some academics have argued that punishments for gay men in the Ming and Qing dynasties were a precedent of growing homophobia in China, which developed into what we have today. However, a closer look reveals that in late Imperial China, social attitudes mainly centered on the shame of the penetrated male, not the supposed sin of homosexuality itself.

Naturally, this begs the question: how did modern homophobia take root in China? How did being gay itself become stigmatised?



An illustration of Dong Xian and Emperor Ai depicting the story of Passion of the cut sleeve



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2. THE CENTURY OF HUMILIATION

The period from 1849 to 1949 is known as the “Century of Humiliation” in China, during which Western powers and Japan encroached on China's sovereignty, resulting in a series of unequal treaties that ceded land, money, and political power to foreign nations. This led to internal political turmoil and a degradation of international status for China. By the early 1900s, multiple Western nations, as well as Japan, held land in China in the form of concessions or colonies. The Qing government's attempts to resist these foreign powers, such as the Opium Wars, were unsuccessful, and the Boxer Rebellion resulted in further humiliation and the stationing of foreign troops in strategic positions within China.

It was becoming clearer, especially to Chinese intellectuals and educated youth (such as those in Peking University) that the West was far more advanced than Imperial China: they had scientific frameworks and superior technologies and were able to crush Chinese forces that were tenfold in number. To these young, educated, and radical individuals, the West appeared to be all but a superior civilization in contrast to China, a sickly, weak nation on the brink of death.



Signing of the treaty of Nanking on board HMS Cornwallis, beginning of China's Century of Humiliation

In the early 20th century, these people gathered in what was known as the “New Culture Movement” (新文化运动). At its core, the New Culture Movement revolved around the belief that China’s own system of knowledge failed. To save the nation, they needed to create a new system, a new ‘canon’ of sorts, based on the induction of Western knowledge and values. This looked like university students carrying banners of “Mr Democracy and Mr Science” (德先生和赛先生) on May 4th 1919 in the famous anti-imperialist May Fourth protests. Peking University professors, Qian Xuantong and Cai Yuanpei advocated for the abolition of Chinese characters in favour of English and Esperanto and looked to the West as the ultimate authority.

What happened next was natural. Professor of History of Gender and Sexuality in China, Wenqing Kang put it best in his book *Obsession: Male Same-Sex Relations in China, 1900-1950*:

“[This] modernising project of Chinese nation-state building involved a reconfiguration of indigenous knowledge about male same-sex relations and contestation of the meaning of sex between men.”

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3. IMPORTING HOMOPHOBIA

The New Culture intellectuals wanted to import Western knowledge to save China. But why, of all things, was homophobia relevant? How did sex and homosexuality become part of the New Culture discourse? Most importantly, how did this change the Chinese discourse around homosexuality?

Firstly, homophobia was cleverly cloaked in the guise of science. Backed with academic papers and fancy-sounding phonetically translated names of white men, the idea that being gay is a disease was articulated exactly the way the New Culture movement most eagerly lapped up.

Secondly, there was a belief, especially among the iconoclast radicals of the New Culture movement, that the Chinese spirit was corrupt and weak. The phrase “东亚病夫” or “sick man of East Asia” was internalised by New Culture. The New Culture author Lu Xun famously titled one of his novels “呐喊” or “Call to Arms” to represent his desire to wake the Chinese people from their perceived slumbering weakness. Unfortunately, homosexuals became the perfect victim of the New Culture’s quest to eliminate “Chinese weakness.” At the time, Western “scientists” characterised gay people as diseased. Therefore, to some New Culture intellectuals, it was a natural conclusion that to eliminate the weakness of China, they needed to purge homosexuality.



呐喊, OR "CALL TO ARMS," LU XUN'S FAMOUS NOVEL COLLECTION AND ONE OF THE MOST IMPORTANT WORKS DURING THE NEW CULTURE MOVEMENT

Thirdly, there is the belief that “国之将亡，必有妖孽”，or “as a nation dies, the unnatural must appear”. The pathologization of homosexuality in Western sexology thus ties it to the perilous state of the nation, since it is deemed unnatural. This, again, made the West’s conception of homosexuality important to the New Culture movement.



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4. IMPLICATIONS FOR CHINESE SOCIETY

We have established that the New Culture movement imported Western homophobia into China. But why was it able to impact the wider society?

The clearest point is the influence of the New Culture movement on the Republican Government in power during the first half of the 1900s. Supporters of this movement were often highly educated. Furthermore, they pointed towards a possible solution to China's problems in the 1900s and used nationalism to their advantage. Therefore, these people and their ideas were well respected in society. So when they flooded the streets and opinion columns demanding westernisation, the Republican Government could hardly ignore them.

It is quite intuitive why this was bad for homosexuals in the early 20th century. For the Republic to westernise, it must imitate a very homophobic Europe and U.S.A. It is no surprise then, that the intolerance of gays and lesbians became more mainstream through the Westernisation efforts of the early Republic of China.

Another factor of note is New Culture's dominance in literature. By labelling other literary schools as traditional and backward, New Culture writers took a strong position in literature. This meant that the ideas they import, such as Western sexology, would have a strong platform in writing and public discourse.

One example of how this happened is the change in the Chinese phrase for homosexuality.

In Chapter 1 of *Obsession*, Kang explains that new Chinese phrases were being created for homosexuality. Whereas the old phrases were generally allusions to famous homosexuals (e.g. 断袖癖, lit. passion of the cut sleeve, in reference to Dong Xian), the new phrase (同性恋爱, lit. love between those of the same gender) was much more scientific and in line with the Western phrase 'homosexual'. Clearly, the introduction of this new phrase was part of the larger reconfiguration of Chinese knowledge with the West as its guide.



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Alarmingly though, the introduction of this Western-sounding phrase for homosexuality was also accompanied by the introduction of the Western conception of homosexuality, i.e. being gay is a disease. This could be seen in a 1933 article in *Shanghai Tidbits*:

"In short, mutual attraction between men and women is very common, while 同性恋爱 (homosexuality), between men or between women, is simply sexual perversion."

This article aimed to explain the new phrase '同性恋爱', as translated from 'homosexuality'. However, by fusing these conceptions, Western homophobia in the form of sexology has been imported into the Chinese discourse.

Another example of New Culture literature's influence on public discourse was what Kang called the heterosexualisation of the Peking Opera. In the late Qing dynasty, there was a norm of praising the sometimes homoerotic relationship between *dan* actors and male patrons in the Peking Opera. However, literary criticism from New Culture associates like the *Beijing Orthodox Patriotic Newspaper*, Lu Xun, and Ba Jin completely flipped this norm, and by 1940, this relationship was completely expunged from public discourse.

Westernisation, brought about by the New Culture movement, reshaped the Chinese view of homosexuality in profound ways. During decades of Republican rule, the homophobia of the West changed China's public discourse as well as government policies, resulting in it seeing homosexuality through a pathologizing and criminalising lens.



Romantic depiction of the May 4th protests, widely regarded as the epitome of the New Culture Movement



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5. CONCLUSION

It is obvious that modern Chinese conservatism toward gay people matches the characteristics of Western homophobia, but this is not something shared by ancient China. I have shown that New Culture and Westernisation in the early 20th Century was the entry point for these new, Western ideas and that they substantially changed China's knowledge structure through government policies and literature alike. There is still a gap to fill between this point and the early 21st century—and a wide one to be sure, seeing to China's tumultuous second half of the 20th century—but we can come to a general understanding of the emergence of Chinese homophobia as we now know it now.

A last word though. In partial defence of New Culture intellectuals: They were born to a nation plagued by internal schisms, backwardness, and semi-colonialism. They had not seen Western ideas and structures fail like we have, with the benefit of hindsight, and they certainly are not should not be considered the antagonists here.

They are more like clumsy protagonists who have created some side quests for posterity in their haste to save their dying world.

Hopefully, those side quests are not too difficult, and use arrow keys instead of WASD.



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THE STRUGGLE BETWEEN THE NEED FOR CLIMATE ACTION AND THE DRIVE TO MAKE PROFIT.



WRITTEN BY ALEX WONDRA
EDITED BY TIFFANY ZHANG

In 2015, representatives from around the world gathered in Paris for the UN Climate Change Conference (COP21), and signed into effect the Paris Agreement. It was a historic international treaty with the ambitious, but vital, goal of limiting the increase in global average temperatures due to climate change under 1.5 degrees celsius, compared to the pre-industrial average. The UN's Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) indicated that a failure to reach this limit would mean droughts, heatwaves and crop-failures around the world because of far more alarming climate change impacts.

Naturally, more money and effort has been put into transitioning from traditional fossil fuel energy sources to renewable sources, such as solar, wind and nuclear. According to the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA), global annual investment in renewable energy increased to 500 billion USD in 2022, from 240 billion USD in 2013 ("Investment"). In Australia alone, one of the largest polluters per capita, around 4000 megawatts of solar panel capacity was installed in 2023 ("2. State of Total Renewables"). Additionally, great strides have been made in transportation electrification and energy storage technologies.

At the same time, a new way of mitigating carbon dioxide emissions called Carbon Capture and Storage (CCS) has been identified as crucial for reaching the goal set out in the Paris Agreement; this works by filtering carbon dioxide from the atmosphere or from fuels before they are burnt, then storing the carbon as a liquid or solid. CCS is an especially important way the Paris Agreement plans to achieve its goals, because it can offset the emissions in essential sectors such as transportation and agriculture, and it can be retrofitted onto existing facilities such as refineries and power plants.

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In July 2023, the European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts (ECMWF) reported the global average temperature for the month to have the highest record ever. Subsequently, the ECMWF detected that the August of 2023 had the second warmest global average temperature: around 1.5°C warmer than the preindustrial average for August 1850-1900 (“Surface Air Temperature for August 2023”). Then, in both September and October of 2023, the ECMWF found a similar trend, with temperature anomalies of 1.75°C and 1.7°C warmer than 1850-1900, respectively (“Surface Air Temperature for September 2023”).

Even though the Paris Agreement’s limit of 1.5°C annual average temperature anomaly has not been breached yet, it is likely that it will happen in 2024, especially with the El Niño trade wind cycle shifting into the warmer phase, compounding the decreased solar dimming effect of COVID related slowdown in transport and manufacturing pollution. So far, no countries are on track to meet their goals for the Paris Agreement, and only 9 are “almost sufficient”, according to Climate Action Tracker.org (“Countries”). The United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) states: “climate change action needs to be massively increased to achieve the goals of the Paris Agreement” (“The Paris Agreement”). Most people would argue our attempt to accelerate the rate of decarbonisation and energy transition is not fast enough to achieve a functioning climate.

Despite hundreds of billions of dollars invested into the development and roll-out of renewable energy, the carbon emissions of the world’s energy sector continue to rise. During the Industrial Revolution of the 1860s, English economist William Jevons observed something similar, where innovations that made coal use more efficient had counter-intuitively increased the consumption of coal. This phenomenon, Jevons’ Paradox, occurs when the price of a product, typically fuel, is reduced by an increase in efficiency, which drives down its price and drives up its demand.

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While the traditional sense of Jevons' Paradox is probably at play here as well, a slightly different interpretation of it also explains how renewable energy and carbon emissions simultaneously increase. We live in a society where almost everything, government or private sector, is mainly driven by profit incentive. When renewable energy development is treated as an investment to increase profits, institutions supplement fossil fuels with renewable energy. Rather than replacing fossil fuel energy sources, new renewable energy is going to meet the ever-increasing energy demand, which is projected to increase another 1.8% in 2024 ("Energy outlook 2024" 1).

For example, with the election of Australian Labour in the 2022 federal election, as well as falling energy prices, 2022 saw an immense growth in renewable energy installations. Origin Energy, an energy company, planned to close down the Eraring coal fired power plant, the largest in Australia, 7 years before scheduled in 2025, because a fall in energy prices and green energy subsidies made it unprofitable. The year saw 5.3 gigawatts of renewable energy capacity added to the Australian National Energy Market (NEM) ("2. State of Total Renewables").

However, the Russia-Ukraine war and other supply chain disruptions led to a jump in energy prices and along with a fear that renewable energy would not come online fast enough for a projected hot and dry summer made the New South Wales (NSW) government reconsider the closure of the Eraring power plant. Because the Australian government's renewable energy strategy is driven by profit, when an increase in energy prices made it profitable to keep fossil fuels, it quickly did so. When Australia's fossil fuel access was threatened, the government doubled down on its reliance on fossil fuels for the foreseeable future, rather than achieve energy security and independence with renewables.

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Because the transition to net zero emissions in Australia and other countries is driven by investment and profit, reducing costs comes before reducing emissions. Since CCS can make fossil fuels that are economically more viable and efficient than renewables “green”, it has been pursued by governments and fossil fuel companies as a way to generate energy with reduced emissions, without too much investment or risk in renewable sources. The world’s first CCS project, the Sleipner West field in the North Sea, was opened in 1996, and is operated by the Norwegian petroleum company Equinor. Often, CCS projects are operated by fossil fuel corporations near oil or gas fields, where they capture the emissions from releasing and processing fossil fuels, and they receive funding from national governments so they can meet their climate targets. Unfortunately, these targets are usually not met, and public funding that could have gone to renewable energy is squandered. In 2000, the IPCC projected that by 2020, there would be 100 large scale CCS projects around the world (Metz 27). Today there are only 13 (Beer). The world’s largest CCS plant is the Gorgon natural gas plant operated by Chevron. It is located about 50 kilometres off the coast of Western Australia, on Barrow Island. After the Gorgon and Jansz-io gas fields with a combined 40 trillion cubic feet of gas were discovered in 2009, the Federal Minister of Environment Peter Garrett approved the construction of the \$300 billion project (“Jansz-lo Gas Field”; Arup).

The Australian government gave \$60 million to Chevron and required them to capture at least 80% of the carbon dioxide emissions due to gas extraction refining at the plant, starting in 2016 (Readfearn). Even though gas production and exportation began in that time period, due to technical issues (including a sand clog up) carbon dioxide capture did not begin until 2019. The same year in 2016, Australia’s national emissions increased by 6.8Mt of carbon dioxide, and Gorgon’s gas production emitted about 4Mt of carbon dioxide, meaning that more than half of Australia’s national increase in emissions were caused by the extraction of liquid natural gas at Gorgon alone (Swann 3).

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As of 2021, the Gorgon project has captured around 5Mt of carbon dioxide, around 30% of the emissions caused by gas processing, short of the 80% limit set by the Australian government (Swann 3). This is barely 2% of all the emissions from the Gorgon plant, including the carbon dioxide released when the gas is finally burnt (Readfearn). Chevron kept 100% of the \$60 million the Australian taxpayers gave them to build CCS, even though very little carbon dioxide was actually stored (Weyler).

Similar failures occurred at other CCS plants across Australia and around the world. For instance, in 2014, the Canadian government spent around \$1.35 billion retrofitting CCS into the Boundary Dam coal power plant (King). Over the course of its lifetime, the Boundary Dam CCS plant has had a target under-performance of about 50%, and is planned to shut down in 2024 due to “serious design issues”, according to SaskPower, the operator of the plant (Muffett 23). In Kemper, Mississippi, Southern Company planned to transform a lignite coal power plant into a “clean coal” plant. The project started construction in 2010 and was planned to finish in 2014, but was years late, and vastly over-budget, reaching a bloated \$7.5 billion spent (Kelly). It was finally cancelled in 2017 because of poor management and major structural problems.

In total, large scale CCS projects around the world captured about 39Mt of carbon dioxide in 2021, about one one-thousandth of the 36Gt of total global carbon dioxide emissions of that year (Beer). According to the Australia Institute, of the various targets set by international organisations such as the International Energy Agency (IEA), the IPCC, and the Council of the European Union, CCS projects around the world have failed to achieve a single one (Browne 4).

A huge reason why CCS rollout has been slower and smaller than projected is because CCS projects tend to be extremely expensive. This is because CSS technology is relatively new and expensive and needs regular maintenance, while subsidies are often insufficient or inconsistent. Carbon needs to be stored somewhere: right now, it is stored deep down in geological formations, which are hard to come by,

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but technological innovations are being made to store carbon more efficiently as a liquid or solid. Furthermore, plants make revenue from selling carbon credits to other institutions so they can label themselves “carbon-neutral”, but the market for these often fluctuates and is much smaller than the investment put into CCS in the first place. According to the Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation (CSIRO), brown coal, black coal and gas with CCS energy sources are more expensive per kilowatts than wind, rooftop photovoltaic and large scale photovoltaic energy systems (Graham 17).

CCS’s two birds - storage and profitability - are killed by one stone: Enhanced Oil Recovery (EOR). EOR is a technique that captures oil that is usually out of reach by traditional production methods by injecting carbon dioxide gas into oil and gas fields to displace fossil fuels, which is then pushed into oil wells. EOR allows oil companies to access fossil fuels that would otherwise be left in the ground. According to the Institute for Energy Economic and Financial Analysis, 73% of all carbon dioxide captured by CCS is used for EOR (Robertson). Carbon dioxide is easily stored in oil and gas deposits and money is made from selling the extracted fossil fuels. Obviously, this is deeply problematic for CCS as a technology that aims to reduce carbon dioxide emissions and take urgent climate action. About two-thirds of oil and gas fields are fossil fuels that are only accessible using EOR, and since carbon dioxide gas is less dense than oil and natural gas, when the recovered fossil fuels are burnt, more emissions are released into the atmosphere than if the carbon wasn’t captured in the first place. CCS as a technology to reduce the impact of unavoidable fossil fuel use has been hijacked by fossil fuel corporations as a way to greenwash their failure to take climate action and make more money.

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In conclusion, our society's focus on economic growth and fixation on profit making hinders genuine climate action to reduce carbon dioxide emissions and fossil fuel reliance. The contradiction between the increasing need for drastic climate action and the ever-present capitalist mode of production creates failures in climate policy and technology like the green energy transition and CCS. Only by deprioritising economic growth at all costs can we begin taking expensive and radical but crucial steps to reducing the negative impact humans have on the natural environment.

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IS TAX A LEGAL DISGUISE FOR THEFT?



WRITTEN BY JIMMY JI
EDITED BY JULIA PIÓRKO BERMIG

Taxation is a fundamental aspect of modern societies. It constitutes the mechanism by which citizens provide the necessary resources for governments to fulfil their respective ultimate responsibilities. Taxation ought not to be considered theft given legal property rights, principle consent granted to the government, and legal definitional complexities. However, some argue that taxation does constitute theft, as it involves a compulsive social contract and violates the non-aggression principle of “natural rights”.

This essay will establish the fundamentals of taxation and set out to divulge the discourse and contentions surrounding taxation, specifically as it relates to property rights, consent, and legality. This essay will focus on whether taxation ought to be categorised as theft, but will not entertain a value judgement of taxation or judge the merits of different taxation models and systems.

Before setting out theoretical claims, one has to operate with a shared understanding of what taxation is.

Taxation refers to the mandatory collection of funds by the government from individuals and businesses to finance public expenditures. It comes in different types to target different economic activities. It plays an essential role in funding services such as infrastructure, education, healthcare, and defence.

Taxation is managed by governmental statutory bodies and is bound to legal frameworks that are supposed to be transparent with all the policies regarding tax such as tax rates, the procedure of payment, who is liable to pay, and how the tax is utilised. Failure to make necessary payments can result in legal repercussions by government authorities.



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Taxation can also serve a redistributive role as the rich who are in higher income brackets may be required to pay more tax and the tax through methods of public services such as universal healthcare or education circles back to help the less wealthy who are in lower income brackets who are not required to pay as much. (Encyclopedia Britannica 2023)

Property rights and the extension of property tax have been one of the most debated subtopics regarding the question. It has been a venue in which philosophers discuss whether or not a right is given naturally or legally.

Realists argue for “natural property rights”, which are essentially property rights that are entirely a moral consensus and not bound by law (such as if a guy building a hut, he has the “natural property rights” of that hut), are fair. In contrast, legalists argue that property rights should be largely controlled by the government and legislation.

Micheal Huemer, a political and ethical philosopher, argues that one might take mostly three broad views when discussing the issue of property rights and evaluates each. (“Moderate” view will not be considered due to its broad nature) (Huemer, 2014)

The Realist View: Property rights are natural rights that individuals naturally possess, and should not be limited or interfered with by legal frameworks.

The Legalist View: Property rights are in every aspect and detail dependent and regulated upon government-created laws and there exist no “natural property rights”



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The extreme realist view is not pragmatic due to morality lacking specificity. This is demonstrated by an example by the economist David Friedman. “If I fire a thousand-megawatt laser at my neighbour’s house, I thereby violate his property rights. On the other hand, if I turn on a lamp in my house, knowing that some photons will go out the window and hit my neighbour’s house, I do not thereby violate his property rights. The only physical difference between these two actions lies in the number and energy levels of the photons that I send my neighbour’s way.” The differences between the two examples then cannot be determined by “natural” or “moral” law and need social constructs to process. (Friedman, 1994)

The extreme legalist view could apply well in urban society with detailed laws bounding all members and property. However, this is also not the ideal solution due to two reasons. Firstly, because of flaws in the legal system. One could object that local law regarding property is simply unfair. For example, a modern person most likely wouldn’t recognize the ancient Roman or Confederate states’ property law as fair as it determines slaves as personal property. However, this could be avoided as legislation erodes as social norms change. Secondly, if an area were to be a global common or rural enough that it is outside of any government’s jurisdiction, then how would the view be applied? As economist Bryan Caplan exemplifies, it would not be vandalism in this theory if someone happens to confront a man living in a rude hut and proceeds to forcefully enter the hut and paint the hut as it isn’t technically the man’s property. (Caplan, 2014)

Lysander Spooner, a 19th-century philosopher, stated that “taxation would not be upheld because no explicit consent was given by individuals to be taxed.” He claims that the citizens have no choice but to enter and comply with this social contract, therefore making it non-consensual. (Spooner, 1852) Although a widely accepted theory argues that the use of the public services that the tax is paying for would be essentially admitting consent to this social contract.



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It is a reciprocating, trade-like relationship between the citizens and government instead of a plunderous one.

However, that is not always true given that some people do not use the services. This is especially true when under a progressive tax system, the wealthy who are paying more tax likely use less public services such as public transport. Philosopher Micheal Huemer also argues that the reciprocating relationship between the government and citizens does not justify taxation. He argues if a thief stops a person in an alleyway, forcefully takes their money but gives them something valuable in return, for example, a book. Even though the person receiving the book may derive more valuable knowledge from the said book for the person to earn even more money than the thief took, it is still a robbery nonetheless. (Huemer, 2017)

However, benefitting from the public resources that are paid by taxation is not the only way that consent is given. Another way the people have given their consent is through being in the status of citizenship. Details of the regulations surrounding taxation are not obscure as they are announced and updated by the government. Citizens also have choices of immigration to no longer remain under the rule of said government. Therefore the people who choose to be citizens of a certain government have given their consent.

Another critic of the social contract theory argues that the punishments that follow when not paying tax make tax theft. The logic behind the theory is say if a person willingly gives money to another person demanding money, it is not theft. However, if a person points a gun at the other person's head and the same interaction occurs, it would be theft because a person can only give consent under free will. This critic doesn't consider the fact that consent is already given in the situation of tax and the punishments such as lawsuits are simply ways to ensure that the contract is completed. Similar to the function of fines on a business contract.



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In summary, the main takeaway from this section is the idea that consent is given by the citizens to the government in ways of using public resources and claiming citizenship status. After discussing the critics of the social contract, it is clear that tax would not count as theft because of legal property rights and consent which is given by citizenship and the use of public resources.

The “Universal Declaration of Human Rights” published by the UN includes “The right to own property” as a basic human right. (Universal Declaration of Human Rights, 2023) Hence, if “natural property rights” are valid, then the tax would be deemed theft because it is charging people money for their human rights. It would then be morally incorrect such that taxing a person on the right of not being tortured is. In comparison, if the property were to be managed by the government and legislation, the property owner should rightfully fulfil the tax requirements as it is part of the legislation that the property is managed by.

In the analysis given above, we can understand that the realist view is not useful on most occasions as the definitions of what is rightful are too blurry. The legalist view proves to work in urban society under the law. However “natural property rights” could exist in occasions where juridical power is not apparent and tax could then be considered theft, hence the compromise would be that tax should remain valid in populations under a government due to this idea of legal property right. This conclusion was also reached by philosophers Liam Murphy and Thomas Nagel similarly in their 2002 book “The Myth of Ownership: Taxes and Justice”. (Murphy & Nagel, 2002)

The social contract theory, sometimes called the fiscal social contract, has been the centre of debate on the topic of whether tax is theft.



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The fiscal social contract theory proposed by Thomas Hobbes and developed by figures such as John Locke, Immanuel Kant, and Jean-Jaques Rousseau describes the nature of tax being that of an assumed contract between citizens and their governments. The citizens pay taxes to trade for public goods and order from the government. The social contract theory is at the heart of the tax discussion as it defines the framework for our relationship with the Government on topics of taxation. (D'Agostino et al., 2021)

The core points of clash regarding the social contract theory lie on the topic of property rights and consent. Property rights have been discussed in the previous section. Consent is important because it determines if the act of taking is theft or not. Such that if one person has taken a book from another person with their consent, it is not theft. If without consent, it would be theft. As philosopher John Locke proclaimed, "The government's authority arises from the consent of the people". Thus the debate centres around whether consent is given or not by the citizens. (Locke, 1689)

French philosopher Frédéric Bastiat described taxation as the term "legal plunder". Legal plunder is defined as anyway the government or legislative bodies plunders or take goods lawfully. (Bastiat, 1850) It lies in comparison with illegal plunder, which theft is categorised as. Bastiat was not at all a supporter of legal plunder, he argued that legal plunder is no different from illegal plunder except that the beneficiaries are shielded by the legal system and people who attempt to defend themselves get penalised. Thus for the context of the debate, Bastiat argues taxation would be theft because it is taking away the property of one citizen and giving it to another, for example, the wealth redistribution from the rich to the poor in a progressive tax system. Bastiat did not assume the citizens have given consent in his argument, but as the previous section concludes, consent is given. Hence disproving his argument.



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While the statement again touches on the idea of property and consent due to its assumption that the government is taking property from citizens without their consent, the purpose it is brought up separately is for its reasoning for differentiating legal and illegal plunder. This means that the government holds the power to define what is and is not theft through legislation. Therefore legal plunder such as taxation cannot technically be defined as theft. That as a rebuttal can seem very pointless due to there being an inherent consensus about theft but is still valid and should be considered.

Derived from the conclusions of the three areas discussed above of property rights, consent, and legality; it is clear that in each part of the debate, the legalist view is more pragmatic and logical than the realist in contemporary society.

Thus, in conclusion, taxation should not be considered theft.



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THE USE OF TELEGRAM IN THE RUSSIAN-UKRAINIAN WAR

WRITTEN BY ALEX TO AND JACK QUE
EDITED BY ELISABETH LEANG

In this article, I will explore the role of telegrams in influencing public opinion re Russian kill claims and tactics in the ongoing Russia Ukraine war. Historically, there is great precedent for overclaiming kills, highlighted by the use of exaggerated media in this war. In 2019, the Ukrainian people were introduced to the power of social media when the former comedian and actor Volodymyr Zelenskyy campaigned to be president and won by a landslide. Over the past 11 months of the Russia-Ukraine war, both sides have tried various media-shaping techniques and narratives to be pushed both to the domestic and international public.

However, one Russian social media platform has stood out above all others, namely, Telegram. Telegram, made in 2013 is similar to Whatsapp in that super-groups of up to millions of people can be created.

In early March, a video surfaced on many Telegram channels of Zelenskyy supposedly asking for his troops to surrender. It was later proved that this was a deepfake. Other than this significant event, the first statistics that many audiences were drawn to in the opening weeks of the war, were the Ukrainian aircrafts claimed to be destroyed by the Russian Ministry of Defence (MINDEF). On the 4th of April 2022, (as shown in the graphic below), the Russians claimed 125 aircrafts were destroyed. Using the figures from the World Air Forces Directory 2022, Ukraine had 131 active (combat-capable) aircraft in the air force, excluding trainers, but including the many obsolete Soviet-era aircraft from the mid Cold War. Moreover, during the Russian attack on

Bakhmut, 5 aircraft (4 aeroplanes and 1 helicopter) were claimed destroyed in one day. As of 24th February 2023, exactly a year after the initial invasion, the claimed aeroplane losses stood at 387, which is frankly comical. Typically, aircraft are not seen to be captured, or resupplied.



Source: Russian Ministry of Defence Telegram



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EDITED BY ELISABETH LEANG

he sheer scale of information outreach that certain Telegram channels have is incredible. The Russian Ministry of Defence Telegram channel has almost 500,000 subscribers, and Solovyov, the Kremlin's main propagandist, has 1.34 million subscribers. As a key player, Solovyov is particularly interesting. As of a decade ago, he declared multiple times that anyone seeking to start a war between Russia and Ukraine was a traitor, since Ukrainians were the "brothers" of Russia. Yet in his Telegram releases and nightly talk show, he advocates for the bombing of civilian centres as well as taking Ukrainian children out of their homes so they can be safe from the "Fascist state." In this way, Solovyov reinforces the talking points made by Putin and the Russian Ministry of Defence.

Other than overclaiming enemy losses, a lot of media releases on Telegram are images and videos, but these are still subjected to deceptive editing. Every media release has its purpose, and it is known that most Russian troops had their phones confiscated upon entering Ukraine. A video can be turned from a successful engagement to no engagement to a failed engagement with some creative editing. In the most egregious cases, these can come from claiming the other side's videos are your own. The media releases that we see as audiences are only a very small part of everything that is happening on the battlefield, and may not accurately reflect reality.

In the actual combat footage that surfaces in Russian Telegram channels, there is many times a stunning lack of evidence. They sometimes include soldiers firing weapons and supposedly getting hits. Historically, there is great precedent for overclaiming kills. Sometimes a field of destroyed Russian vehicles can be turned into a reversal of a Ukrainian offensive with some creative changes to the video title. An interesting claim to look at here is the Russians using their tanks as indirect artillery fire. The claim here is that these tanks can hit targets up to 10km away. The most modern Russian tank in Ukraine right now, the T-90 series, has a maximum effective range of 6km, to say nothing of the museum pieces that have also been deployed, such as unmodernised T-62s.

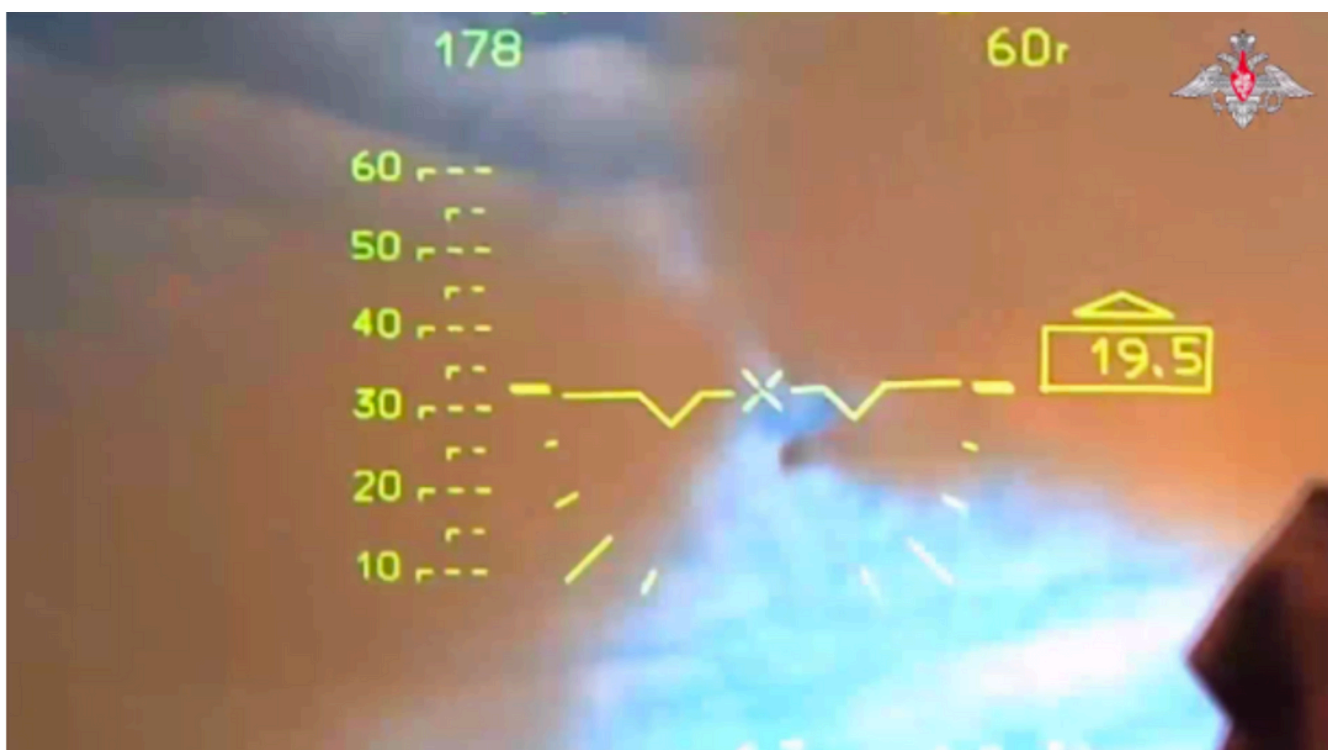


THE USE OF TELEGRAM IN THE RUSSIAN-UKRAINIAN WAR

WRITTEN BY ALEX TO AND JACK QUE
EDITED BY ELISABETH LEANG

There are more examples for this, such as the Guncam footage of Russian attack helicopters, claiming the destruction of Ukrainian “AFU armour and a command and control post”. In the footage, we can see the helicopter flies dangerously close to the ground, then tilts 19.5 degrees up, and fires a volley of unguided missiles, then immediately dives back down whilst dumping out flare and chaff from the rear. This is a pitch up attack, which can increase the range of these unguided rockets to up to 4 km. The reason behind the pitch up is to avoid the MANPADS risk of Ukraine forces by shooting outside of line of sight, and hoping that you do not get detected.

The pitch up allows for increased range of its missiles, however the dispersion increases dramatically, and estimates suggest that only half the rockets can land in a 100 metre diameter. There have been questions raised about the sustainability of risking such an expensive system whilst using it as indirect airborne artillery. Media releases like this show us the true state of the battlefield - specifically on how pilots need to put great effort into minimising the danger presented by anti-air threats, and puts a more human perspective on the conflict than data on a screen.



Ka-52 seen pitched up to an angle of 19.5 degrees to fire a volley of rockets (orange smoke streaks)



The helicopter immediately turns tail and dumps out flares (bright spots are flares)

Source: Russian Ministry of Defence Telegram



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TO WHAT EXTENT DO DIFFERENT NEWS SOURCES ENGAGE IN MEDIA MANIPULATION THROUGH HEADLINES?

WRITTEN BY JASON R.
EDITED BY TIFFANY ZHANG

INTRODUCTION

The global landscape is changing. The internet is revolutionizing access to information and we can now learn about unfolding events in unprecedented detail in astoundingly tiny amounts of time. At first, this may seem a blessing. However, it has quickly become a curse where misinformation is easier than ever to spread. Some tout traditional news as a way to avoid online misinformation, however it is far from immune from spreading this misinformation. Luckily, as this problem has risen, solutions have appeared just as quickly. Fact checking websites such as Snopes and Politifact are incredibly valuable resources when it comes to verifying online news. However, they only help with the content of articles; if a headline is misleading or editorialized, these sites will not capture and fact check it. While this may seem irrelevant, the urgency surrounding the accuracy of headlines comes from a simple fact: most people just skim headlines without reading the article. Around 60% of all articles shared on social media never get clicked on (Gabiolkov et al. 2016), especially because people cannot afford to spend time reading every single article that shows up on their social media feeds. This highlights the importance of discussing how misinformation spreads through headlines.

METHOD

In this article, I will be exploring headlines by 9 news agencies during the period of February 5–28 2022, the leadup to the Russian invasion of Ukraine on the 24th of February and the few days following it. I am specifically focusing on American news websites, and will not include news sources from other countries to allow more consistent terminology when analyzing political ideology; the left in the US is not the same as the left in the UK, India or Singapore. The news sources I chose are the Associated Press, CNN, Daily Wire, Fox News, MSNBC, National Review, Newsweek, New York Post, and NPR. To balance the political beliefs represented in this sample, I used media bias rankings from AllSides, with one news source described as “left wing”, three “leaning left wing”, one “center”, two described as “leaning right wing”, and two “right wing”.



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The first step after choosing my news sources was to aggregate all the headlines on the Russia-Ukraine crisis in the time period mentioned above from each source. I used the Wayback Machine to get all of these headlines, 841 of which I rated. To automate this process, I used Python to scrape each of the websites, searching for keywords related to Ukraine and Russia in headlines.

Once I had all of the headlines, I classified them based on two criteria: objectivity and truth. Both were on a scale of one to five.

First, on the objectivity scale, one means the headline is entirely editorialized, and five means the headline is entirely objective. An objective headline is considered one which only contains factual information with no opinion inserted, while an editorialized headline is one which contains only opinion and no information. I gave slight penalties to headlines containing a quote with a strong opinion, and if a quotation was not attributed within the headline to a specific person or party, I did not consider it a quote. I will give an example of a headline with low objectivity and one with high objectivity, both from Fox News. An example of a low objectivity headline is “Tucker: Biden has been played by Putin”: this headline contains little factual information and only provides the opinion of an analyst on Fox News. A headline with high objectivity may look as such: “Trump weighs in on GOP bill that would block military assistance to Ukraine until US border is secured”. The headline only contains a statement of fact – that Trump has weighed in on a bill proposed in congress – and gives no opinion on Trump or the bill.

The second scale is the truthfulness scale, which I decided to make a purely retrospective metric. This does lead to some articles that were believed to be true at the time being penalized, but genuine belief an article is true at the time does not reduce the effect of misinformation—intent matters not, only impact. A fully false article with no redeemable truth would be given a 1 on the scale, while a fully true article would get a 5. The same rules about quotations and unattributed quotations apply. To illustrate, I will give examples from the Daily Wire. An example which got a very low score was “Has Putin Already Won The War?”, posted around the start of the war. An example which got a high score was “Heartbreaking Footage Shows Ukrainian Nurses Comforting Newborns In Makeshift Bomb Shelter”. Note that this headline is editorialized, hence having a low objectivity score, but it has a high truth score because the video that the headline speaks of is real. It is not objective but it is true.



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ANALYSIS OF OBJECTIVITY

My analysis told me exactly what I expected: modern day news lacks objectivity. Here's the data for articles about the Russia-Ukraine war: (table attached below)

Source	Objectivity	Standard Deviation	% Below 4	% Below 3
AP	3.945	0.815	31.081	2.740
CNN	4.134	0.757	19.403	1.493
Daily Wire	3.705	1.051	42.708	12.632
Fox News	3.588	0.875	46.614	9.200
MSNBC	3.600	0.960	50.000	6.667
National Review	3.848	0.916	39.394	3.030
Newsweek	4.040	0.840	29.600	1.613
NYPPost	3.590	0.927	47.170	12.381
NPR	4.182	0.605	10.606	0.000



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To some extent, these objectivity levels are concerningly low. NPR is the best source for objectivity by a decent margin (though CNN comes close), which was not too surprising since I personally always viewed NPR as a reliable source of news. CNN definitely surprised me, however: I had always felt CNN was too focused on clicks. This high objectivity could be because the Russia-Ukraine crisis sold itself—there was no need to overly editorialize headlines about the topic since coverage on the war would get clicks regardless of how much it is sensationalized. On the other end, despite the Daily Wire’s average objectivity being only 4th worst, it has a high standard deviation indicating there is a large spread, and these fluctuations led me to consider the Daily Wire as the worst of these sources.

Proving this is that 12% of its articles are given an objectivity rating of below 3. The Daily Wire skews its average objectivity upwards by having some good and objective headlines, but purposefully incites interactions for most of its articles through emotional manipulation. Here’s one such headline with an objectivity ranking of 2, written on 2022/02/25:

Not A Joke: John Kerry Is Worried War In Ukraine Will Distract World Leaders From Climate Change

This headline is designed to make readers angry. First, it informs readers about someone’s apathy towards a dire and serious war. Second, the headline involves a topic that the Daily Wire often uses as an example of a frivolous issue (climate change), which would further anger regular readers. Third, the headline starts with “Not a Joke,” implicitly shaming readers if you think the rest of the headline is describing something reasonable. Every part of this headline is crafted to generate an emotional reaction from the reader, which is generally the purpose and the impact of low objectivity in headlines

ANALYSIS OF TRUTH

The results for the truthfulness of articles about the Russia-Ukraine war held more interesting results:



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Truth	Average	Standard Deviation	% Below 3	% Below 4
AP	4.603	0.795	2.740	8.108
CNN	4.507	0.766	2.985	10.448
Daily Wire	4.168	0.930	4.211	22.917
Fox News	4.104	0.805	4.000	18.327
MSNBC	4.300	0.646	1.667	6.667
National Review	4.288	0.576	0.000	6.061
Newsweek	4.339	0.815	4.032	13.600
NYPPost	4.181	0.818	3.810	17.925
NPR	4.515	0.588	0.000	4.545

Most noticeably, levels of truth are much higher than levels of objectivity. Only two sources have an objectivity of above 4.1 while all truth levels are above that threshold; many sources have 40–50% of their articles at a 3 or below in objectivity, while the highest percentage of articles at a 3 or below in truth is 23%, with the majority of sources having 10% or less of their articles rated a 3 in truth or lower. The high levels of truth in the news illustrates something important: in an internet era where speed is required and misinformation is rampant, traditional news manages to avoid the shortcomings of social media. Even though the Russia-Ukraine war was rapidly unfolding, likely resulting in tight deadlines for editors and journalists, high levels of truth were still maintained.



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Of the sources analyzed, AP News managed to have the highest level of truth with CNN and NPR practically tied in a somewhat distant second, and the rest long behind them. I would give NPR the tiebreaker over CNN because, despite their nearly identical average truth score, its standard deviation and consequently the percentage of its articles scoring below 4 and 3 are lower than those of CNN's. Consistent truth is important; without consistency, there is an onus on the reader to figure out what's true or not which—for the average person—is an unfair expectation, especially since articles from a seemingly trusted source are assumed to be true.

CONCLUSIONS

News has come remarkably far. The fact that an unfolding conflict like the Russia-Ukraine war nearly halfway around the world can be reported mostly accurately by American news in almost real time is remarkable. However, news is also more sensationalist than ever, and the impacts of this are far more harmful than misinformation. Misinformation can be disproven, but sensationalized headlines cannot be, since technically nothing is incorrect. News sources that want to manipulate the public mind have realized that the most effective method of doing so is through sensationalization – they attempt to impact what people feel about certain events and certain actors without lying. There's also a noticeable effect where untruth and sensationalization tends to be on the margins, as we saw with the example of The Daily Wire where it has a slightly higher objectivity than some other sources but a large number of articles with a low objectivity score. To maintain some credibility news sources must manage to strike a balance between manipulating people and providing trustworthy and accurate reporting so as to not be immediately dismissed. I think that reading articles will never quite go back into style, so we must make sure that news sources remain responsible when it comes to crafting headlines. News sources certainly have the monetary incentive (in generating clicks and thus ad revenue) to sensationalize their headlines, so there must be more accountability in media headline creation.



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AUTHORS & EDITORS

Xiaoyao Lu

Alex Wondra

Jimmy Ji

Alex To

Jack Que

Jason R.

Ai Jian

Myra Dhingra

Julia Piórko Bermig